US Clinical Electives at a Glance

How to get the placement, and the visa question that decides what you are allowed to do when you arrive.

TIME-SENSITIVE: A ROUTE IS CLOSING THIS MONTH

Yale School of Medicine's published notice states the **AAMC VSLO "Free Mover" pathway concludes in August 2026**. That pathway let international students *without* institutional VSLO access apply directly. After it closes, VSLO is the only application route there, and students whose institutions do not participate cannot be accepted.

If your medical school is not a VSLO participating institution, this is the thing to deal with first. Confirm the position with the AAMC and with each host you are targeting.

PART ONE — GETTING THE PLACEMENT

STEP	WHAT TO DO
1	**Check your school is a VSLO participating institution.** The AAMC publishes the list. Everything else depends on this.
2	Create your VSLO account and complete your profile. It attaches to every application, so accuracy beats speed.
3	Search the catalogue. Only opportunities you are eligible for are visible — filter by specialty, location, expenses.
4	**Read each host's own page inside the system.** Their dates, fees and eligibility rules override any general advice.
5	Your home school reviews and releases the application. Build in time for your dean's office.
6	Submit and wait. Many hosts review only after a deadline, not on a rolling basis.

Do not email departments or faculty directly. Weill Cornell states that applicants who contact clinical departments will be disqualified. Yale does not accept direct or unsolicited applications.

WHAT YOU WILL BE ASKED FOR

- **Official transcript** — usually uploaded by your school, not you
- **AAMC Standard Immunization Form** — start this the month you decide, not the month you apply. It is the commonest cause of a missed deadline
- **TB clearance**, often within a year of your dates
- **Liability insurance** — a commonly stated minimum is $1M per occurrence and $3M aggregate. Check early whether you can obtain this in your country
- **CV** and a short **statement of intent** (UCLA asks for 150 words or fewer)
- **Letter of recommendation** from clinical faculty
- **Proof of good standing** and completed core clerkships

PART TWO — THE VISA. FOLLOW THE BRANCH THAT APPLIES TO YOU.

START HERE: the only question that matters
Are you still enrolled in medical school?

YES — enrolled

B-1 — ELECTIVE CLERKSHIP PROVISION

Hands-on clinical work is available to you.

The Foreign Affairs Manual recognises B-1 for a student at a foreign medical school taking an unpaid elective clerkship at a US medical school's hospital.

Conditions: unpaid, no stipend, no compensation.

Typically 3rd or 4th year. B category permits a limited stay.

NO — already graduated

B-1 — OBSERVATION ONLY

The clerkship provision does not apply to you.

A separate published basis allows a physician to enter and observe US medical practice, provided there is no remuneration from a US source.

That is an observership. Not hands-on.

If a provider sells a graduate a "hands-on rotation", ask which category.

A THIRD ROUTE: J-1 STUDENT INTERN — only if the host will sponsor you

Requires a designated sponsor issuing **Form DS-2019**, plus **Form DS-7002** signed by you and your supervisor before it is issued. Sponsor must verify your English. Minimum about 3 weeks; maximum 12 months per degree level. You must return to your home institution afterwards. **Participation after completing your degree is not permitted.**

Many hosts decline to sponsor this for a short elective because of the administrative burden. Where offered, it is a cleaner status.

TIMING — WORK BACKWARDS FROM THE START DATE

- **Catalogues open early.** UCLA's 2026–27 catalogue opened for viewing 26 January, applications 9 March.
- **Watch the international-only windows.** Harvard accepts international students for rotations **October to March only**.
- **Host deadlines are firm.** Weill Cornell requires applications at least **60 days** before the start and post-acceptance documents **30 days** before — and no more than six months ahead, final year only.
- **Then the visa.** Appointment waits run to months at many posts. Check current wait times at travel.state.gov *before* committing to dates.

The squeeze: not more than six months ahead, not less than sixty days ahead, final year only, in the months they allow. Your real window can be a few weeks wide.

SEVEN WAYS PEOPLE LOSE THE CYCLE

- **Emailing a department to make their case.** At several institutions this disqualifies you outright.
- **Assuming their school participates in VSLO.** Check the published list first.
- **Missing the international-only month windows.**
- **Leaving the immunisation form until last.**
- **Booking flights before the visa is issued.** Issuance is never guaranteed.
- **Not checking whether the host takes international students at all.** Some state plainly that they do not.
- **Underestimating total cost** — host fees, VSLO fees, insurance, flights, accommodation, visa fees.

WHERE TO VERIFY EVERYTHING ON THIS PAGE

students-residents.aamc.org — VSLO · aamc.org — participating institutions · travel.state.gov · travel.state.gov — appointment wait times · esta.cbp.dhs.gov · j1visa.state.gov · eCFR Title 22 Part 62 · each host's own visiting-student page

READ THIS BEFORE YOU ACT ON ANY OF IT

This summary describes published rules and processes. **It does not tell you what you personally qualify for, and it cannot.** Immigration categories turn on individual facts, the rules change without announcement, and consular officers exercise discretion. Visa issuance is never guaranteed. Institution-specific dates, fees and eligibility rules are illustrations of the pattern, not commitments by those institutions — confirm the current cycle directly. Where your circumstances are unusual — a gap since graduation, a prior refusal, a complicated academic record — that is exactly when a qualified immigration lawyer is worth the money.

Information, not advice. Verified 27 August 2026 against aamc.org, travel.state.gov, j1visa.state.gov, the eCFR and host institution pages.
Magna-Q Pathway Series · v1.0 · Re-verify by 1 December 2026 · Full guide available free